Midterm Presentation: Country Selection

Student brief | Business Projects WT 2026/27 | Case: Julius Meinl, entering Latin America

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Yellow text in square brackets is still to be confirmed by the instructor.

1 At a glance

Task	Score the six Latin American countries on one common set of criteria. Each group collects the data for **its allocated country**, presents that country's results (Part A, scoring method) and analyses the coffee industry there (Part B). The six country results together answer which market Julius Meinl should enter.
Countries	Argentina, Brazil, Chile, Colombia, Mexico and Uruguay. One country per group (allocation in section 3). All groups use the same criteria and indicators.
Format	Group presentation of 20 minutes plus one Excel file with your data and industry analysis. Discussion time: 10 minutes.
Weight	30 % of the course grade (Presentation 2 of 3).
Presentation	Session 5, Monday 16 November 2026, 08:00 to 11:00, room TC.5.04
Files due	Monday 16 November 2026, 08:00 on Canvas: one presentation file and one Excel file, named GroupX_Midterm and GroupX_Midterm_Data; your country's data are due in the shared Google Sheet earlier (Step 3).
Coaching	Session 3 (Mon 19 Oct) and session 4 (Mon 9 Nov): an online Zoom coaching session of 20 minutes per group (see section 12).
Builds on	The content presentation (Presentation 1) on market selection tools and weighting methods.
AI	Encouraged. List every tool you used and check every number (section 10).

2 The case in brief

Julius Meinl is a family-owned Viennese coffee roaster, founded in 1862 and now in its fifth generation. It sells in more than 70 countries, mostly through local distribution partners, in hospitality (cafés, restaurants and hotels, HoReCa) and in grocery retail. It has no own sales organisation in export markets, so the partner is the sales force. In Latin America Julius Meinl is not present, or only marginally.

The company asks three questions: **which** Latin American market should it enter, **how** could entry look and with what kind of partner, and **how** should the brand be positioned and marketed? Your midterm answers the first question. The final presentation answers the other two.

Julius Meinl has no preferred country. It wants to learn from your work, and different answers from different groups are welcome. It values three things: a recommendation it could act on (not a list of options), evidence it can follow including where the evidence is thin, and a clear statement of what you would **not** do, and why.

The hard question your selection must keep in mind

Several of these countries grow and roast their own coffee. Why would cafés, hotels, retailers and consumers there choose a coffee brand from Vienna, and who exactly would do so?

Julius Meinl sells Viennese coffee house culture (service, hospitality, the idea of taking time for a cup of coffee) rather than the bean itself. Its own assumption is that this works where a European-influenced coffee culture already exists and where hotels serve many European guests. This is unverified. Your analysis can support or challenge it.

Ground rules. Use public data only. Julius Meinl provides no internal figures (sales, margins, prices, partner names) and you do not need them. If you contact companies or people for your research, you do so as students on a university project, not on behalf of Julius Meinl. Julius Meinl has offered feedback on your market selection once the rankings are in. Its Group Export team answers questions that are bundled for the whole course: collect yours and send them to the instructor [process to be confirmed].

3 What you deliver

Country allocation (one country per group, drawn at random). Your allocated country is the country you present in **both** Part A and Part B:

Group	Your country (Parts A and B)
Group 1	Argentina
Group 2	Chile
Group 3	Mexico
Group 4	Colombia
Group 5	Uruguay
Group 6	Brazil

Part A: scoring method (the core of the midterm). All groups apply the **same criteria and indicators**, so the six country results can be compared. Your group collects the data for its allocated country, scores it, and shows how it ranks against the other five, how stable that rank is, and what you recommend for Julius Meinl regarding this country.

Part B: industry analysis. Search for statistics and facts on the coffee industry in your allocated country (hotels, restaurants, cafes and private end customers) and present them. Section 8 describes the content.

Suggested time budget for the 20 minutes:

Block	Content	Minutes
1 Decision and criteria	Case in one slide, the decision your model makes, the common criteria and your country	3
2 Data and method	Your country's data, normalisation, weights and where they come from	4
3 Results	Your country's scores by dimension, its rank among the six, what drives the result	3
4 Robustness	What happens to your country's rank when assumptions change	3
5 Recommendation and limits	Enter, wait or stay out? Conditions, what not to do, what would change your mind	2
6 Part B	Industry statistics of your country by segment	4
7 Wrap-up	Three key messages	1

Lead with the answer: show your recommendation for your country on slide 2, then show how you got there. Put technical detail (full data tables, formulas) in an appendix.

4 Part A (scoring method) in eight steps, along PESTEL

The steps follow the standard logic of composite indicators and weighted scoring (OECD/JRC, Cavusgil), organised along the six **PESTEL dimensions** (political, economic, social, technological, environmental, legal). Each step lists what to hand in. The shared Google Sheet "Country scoring model" [link to be added] mirrors the steps (section 9).

Step 1 Search indicators for each PESTEL dimension

Your group receives a copy of the Google Sheet "PESTEL indicator search" [link to be added]. For each PESTEL dimension search for criteria (indicators) that could describe the six countries for Julius Meinl. For every criterion give the definition, unit, direction, the **source name and a working link**, and the steps another group needs to find the data. Check that data exist for all six countries. The source is essential: if your criterion is selected, the groups of the other five countries must find the numbers for their countries with your instructions. Questions about the sheet go to arne.floh@wu.ac.at. **Hand in:** your completed copy of the sheet by [date]. The instructor merges the proposals of all groups and selects the final criteria: 5 political, 10 economic, 10 social, 10 technological, 5 environmental and 5 legal (section 5). Then the shared sheet "Country scoring model" is published with the selected criteria.

Step 2 Frame the decision and apply the common criteria

Write one sentence that says what your model decides, for example: "Which of the six countries offers Julius Meinl the best prospects for launching a premium coffee brand through local partners in hospitality and retail?" Then apply the **common criteria**: the 45 indicators the instructor selected from the group proposals, grouped under the six PESTEL dimensions (section 5). **All groups use the same criteria unchanged**, so the six country results are comparable. Rules:

- Every indicator has a fixed definition, unit and direction (higher is better or lower is better). Do not change them.
- Qualitative criteria use the same rubric in every group (anchors on the Rubrics sheet). Two team members score independently, then agree and write down the reason.
- You may add an extra indicator of your own, but label it clearly as an extra: it stays out of the common score.

Hand in: the decision sentence (slide 2) and a short rationale for each PESTEL dimension: why it matters for Julius Meinl.

Step 3 Collect the data for your country

Collect the values of your allocated country for all 45 indicators and enter them in the yellow cells of your country on the Data sheet of the shared Google Sheet. **You only enter the numbers** (rubric indicators: a whole number from 1 to 5); the sheet does everything else. Use the latest year available and record the year and source (name and link) for every number. If a value is missing, substitute a comparable indicator with the instructor's agreement [process to be confirmed] and document it. Follow the definitions exactly: the other groups use your numbers. **Hand in:** your country's data and sources, entered by [deadline]. Normalisation, scores, ranks and the weight-set comparison appear automatically as soon as all six countries are complete; the other sheets are locked.

Step 4 Normalisation: automatic, you interpret

You do not normalise anything yourself. As soon as all six countries are entered, the Google Sheet rescales every indicator across the six countries and applies the direction (higher or lower is better) automatically. Indicators come in different units (US dollars, percent, index points), so subtracting the mean (centering) alone would not be enough: it fixes the zero point but not the unit. The sheet therefore gives two normalised scores:

- **Normalised sheet (min-max, 0 to 100):** the best country scores 100 and the weakest 0 on each indicator.
- **T-scores sheet:** z-score (subtract the mean, divide by the standard deviation), then T = 50 + 10 x z. A T-score of 50 is the average of the six countries and 60 is one standard deviation better.

Caution with six countries: min-max scaling exaggerates small differences, because it stretches the weakest and the best country to 0 and 100 even if the real gap is tiny. T-scores keep the distances in the data and are not capped. Compare both for your country and explain where they differ (Pollesch and Dale; JRC pocket guide). **Hand in:** one slide with the normalised scores of your country and your comment.

Step 5 Weights: fixed upfront

The weights are **set by the instructor before data collection** and are the same for all groups (sheet Weights, section 6). They are not part of your model choices, so nobody can tune them to a preferred ranking. Understand them: explain on one slide why each PESTEL dimension has the weight it has, using Julius Meinl's priorities, and say whether you would weigh differently and why. **Hand in:** the explanation slide.

Step 6 Aggregate

Score(country) = sum of weight x normalised score (weighted sum), calculated by the sheet. Note what the weighted sum implies: a large market can offset a poor business climate (full compensation). If some conditions are knock-outs for Julius Meinl (for example, import barriers that make premium pricing impossible), say so: this is where a non-compensatory filter would apply (screening funnel, Cavusgil 1985). **Hand in:** the score and rank of your country, with the scores by PESTEL dimension (sheet Scores, block C), on one slide.

Step 7 Test robustness: other weights (required)

A ranking is decision support, not truth. The required test is the same for every group: look at the scores and ranks that the sheet recalculates with four alternative weight sets (sheet Scores, blocks A and B), next to the fixed baseline. Weights are per PESTEL dimension (sum 100) and split equally among the indicators of the dimension.

PESTEL dimension	Baseline	Equal	Economy-led	Access-led	Society-led
Political	15	17	10	20	10
Economic	25	17	40	15	20
Social	25	17	20	15	40
Technological	10	17	10	5	10
Environmental	5	16	5	5	5
Legal	20	16	15	40	15
Sum	100	100	100	100	100

Baseline reflects Julius Meinl's priorities. **Equal** is the neutral benchmark. **Economy-led** puts purchasing power and market size first. **Access-led** puts regulation, import conditions and political risk first, for a company without a sales organisation abroad. **Society-led** puts coffee culture and tourism first. Report the result in one table or chart: the rank and score of each country under each weight set. Answer in words: Is your country's rank stable? Which weights change the order, and why? **Hand in:** robustness sheet and one slide.

Step 8 Interpret and recommend

Turn the results into a decision about **your country**: how it ranks among the six, its strengths and risks by dimension, whether you recommend entering now, later or not at all, under which conditions, what you would **not** do, and what would change your mind. Compare your result briefly with the ranking of the other countries. Connect the result to the hard question in section 2. Be open about limits: proxy indicators, data quality, subjective weights, and that Mexico is not in South America. Most indices were built for other exporters (the globalEDGE index, for example, takes a US perspective), so adapt to the view from Vienna: distance, EU import conditions and the Julius Meinl business model. **Hand in:** recommendation slide and limitations slide.

5 The common criteria, grouped by PESTEL (example list)

The final criteria are selected by the instructor from the proposals of all groups (Step 1): 5 political, 10 economic, 10 social, 10 technological, 5 environmental and 5 legal, 45 in total. The list below is the instructor's example list that starts the search; the selected list may differ. The weight of a dimension is split equally among its indicators. Units, definitions and sources are on the Indicators sheet of the Google Sheet; rubric scores (R) follow the Rubrics sheet.

PESTEL dimension	Indicators
Political (5 indicators, weight 15)	Political stability and absence of violence (WGI) Government effectiveness (WGI) Corruption Perceptions Index Country risk rating (Coface) EU trade agreement with the country (R)

PESTEL dimension	Indicators
Economic (10, weight 25)	GDP per capita, PPP GDP growth, projected (IMF) Household consumption per capita Inflation (lower is better) Income inequality, Gini (lower is better) Exchange-rate change against the US dollar (lower is better) Population International tourism receipts Coffee imports, HS 0901 Applied tariff on roasted coffee, HS 0901.21, EU origin (lower is better)
Social (10, weight 25)	Coffee consumption per capita International tourist arrivals Share of visitors from Europe Urban population share Cafe culture (R) European influence on coffee culture (R) Human Development Index Specialty cafes in the capital (own count) International-brand hotels in the capital (own count) Tertiary school enrolment
Technological (10, weight 10)	Individuals using the Internet Logistics Performance Index Global Innovation Index Online retail and food delivery share Account ownership, adults Mobile cellular subscriptions Fixed broadband subscriptions Secure Internet servers E-Government Development Index Container port traffic
Environmental (5, weight 5)	Demand for certified and sustainable coffee (R) Environmental Performance Index Climate vulnerability and readiness (ND-GAIN) Domestic coffee production (lower is better: local competition) Packaging and waste rules for imported goods (R)
Legal (5, weight 20)	Regulatory quality (WGI) Rule of law (WGI) Product, labelling and certification requirements for coffee (R) Trademark protection (R) Rules for ending a distribution agreement (R)

The competitive landscape and the hotel dimension are covered qualitatively in Part B (industry analysis) and in your recommendation. Look up the current status of trade agreements and tariffs and record the date.

6 Weights and aggregation: fixed upfront

The instructor fixes the weights of the six PESTEL dimensions before the data are collected, so that all groups work with the same model and nobody can steer the ranking by choosing weights afterwards. The baseline weights follow Julius Meinl's priorities. Within a dimension every indicator has the same weight.

PESTEL dimension	Weight	Why
Political	15	Stability and a workable relationship with the EU matter for a long-term partner model, but Julius Meinl serves private buyers
Economic	25	Premium prices need purchasing power; Julius Meinl names it as a key dimension
Social	25	Coffee culture and tourism are the foundation of the Viennese coffee house idea
Technological	10	Logistics and online reach support distribution, but are not decisive
Environmental	5	Sustainability demand is a niche factor for now
Legal	20	Import conditions and regulation decide whether premium pricing and a partner model are feasible

Aggregation is the weighted sum of the normalised indicator scores. Weighted sums let strengths offset weaknesses; the Access-led weight set in Step 7 shows how much your result depends on that. Other methods (AHP, best-worst, rank-order centroid, entropy) belong to the content presentation (Presentation 1); here the weights are given.

7 The presentation

- 20 minutes plus 10 minutes of discussion. Rehearse to time. Slide limit: 20 slides plus appendix. Every slide has an action title that states its message.
- Show results visually: a ranking chart, a score-by-dimension chart, a rank-range chart for robustness. Avoid slides that only list formulas.
- Every number on a slide carries its source in a footnote (short name and year); the full reference is in the Data sheet.
- Make your model understandable in two minutes: criteria, weights, and what the ranking looks like. Details go to the appendix.
- Be ready for questions on weights, data choices and robustness. Julius Meinl's questions will be "is this a good first market?" and "what would you not do?"

8 Part B: industry analysis

Part B is about **facts and statistics**. Search for information and numbers on the coffee industry in your allocated country and present them, segment by segment, as an evidence base for Julius Meinl: how big is each segment, how is it structured, how is it developing, and what does that mean for a premium newcomer from Vienna? Focus on the hospitality customers Julius Meinl serves, plus private end customers:

Segment	Statistics to search for (examples)
Hotels	Number of hotels and rooms by category; international hotel chains and brands; occupancy and overnight stays of international guests; food and beverage spending; coffee brands served in the top hotels
Restaurants	Number of restaurants and sales, growth; chains versus independents; out-of-home spending on food and coffee; typical price of a coffee on the menu
Cafes	Number of cafes and specialty cafes; chains versus independents; sales and growth; price of an espresso and a cappuccino in premium cafes; main roasters and brands used
Private end customers	Coffee consumption per capita; share of coffee at home versus out of home; household spending on coffee; who drinks premium and specialty coffee (age, income, city); buying habits and attitudes (sustainability, origin, convenience)

Add three short blocks that frame the statistics:

- **Value chain.** Production and green coffee trade (imports, domestic production), roasting, import and distribution, hospitality and retail. Mark where Julius Meinl would enter (it exports roasted coffee from Vienna) and which steps depend on a local partner.
- **Rules of the game.** Import conditions (tariffs, certification, labelling, customs) and regulation that affect the industry. Check the current status of trade agreements and record the date.
- **Trends and outlook.** For example premiumisation, specialty coffee, the recovery of out-of-home consumption, sustainability expectations, new formats. Base every trend on a source.

Rules for the statistics. Every figure needs value, unit, year, source and link. Use the most recent year available. If no figure exists, say so and use a transparent estimate or proxy (for example Google Maps count of cafes in the capital, with date and method) and label it as an estimate. Compare sources when they disagree. Mark the source type of each figure (official statistic, industry report, own count or estimate) in the source list.

Sources. Euromonitor Passport and Statista (WU library); USDA Foreign Agricultural Service annual coffee reports and International Coffee Organization statistics; national statistics offices and tourism boards; hotel and restaurant associations; UN Comtrade and ITC Trade Map for coffee trade (HS 0901); WKO AUSSENWIRTSCHAFT country reports; EU Access2Markets. A short online scan of brands and prices (cafes, restaurants, hotels) supplies prices and brand evidence. Record each observation with brand, channel, product, price and unit, URL and date.

Hand in: (1) the PowerPoint slides: **all numbers are presented in the slides**, three to five slides with an overview of the industry, key figures per segment (use charts and tables) and the main trends, closing with the implication for Julius Meinl (where is there room for a Viennese coffee house brand, and where is none?); (2) a **source list** in Excel or Google Sheets (template "Industry sources") with one row per number or fact on your slides: segment, statistic, value, unit, year, source, source type, link, date accessed, slide number and quality.

9 The Google Sheet and your Excel file

Shared Google Sheet "Country scoring model" [link to be added] for all six groups. You enter data only in the yellow cells of your own country (the numbers, with year and source for documentation); the rest is automatic and locked. Sheets:

Sheet	Content
Instructions	Purpose, rules, colour code, allocation of countries
Weights	PESTEL weights (baseline and four alternatives), weight of each indicator. Fixed by the instructor
Indicators	The 45 common indicators grouped by PESTEL, with unit, direction and source
Data	Value, year and source for each country; your own country is entered by you
Normalised and T-scores	Automatic: two normalisations by formula, min-max (0 to 100) and T-score (50 + 10 x z). Nothing to enter
Scores	Weighted scores and ranks for all weight sets, score by PESTEL dimension, T-score check
Rubrics	Anchors for the four qualitative indicators

Your Excel file (hand-in): a short workbook with (1) a copy of your country's data and sources, (2) the Part B source list (template "Industry sources" [link to be added]): every source behind the numbers on your industry slides, and (3) a list of the AI tools you used. The industry numbers themselves are shown in the presentation. Sources need URL, date accessed and who collected the data. Results come from formulas, not pasted values; inputs and formulas are visibly different.

10 Use of AI

You are explicitly encouraged to use (generative) AI tools, for example to find and summarise sources, explain a method, write Excel formulas or Python/R code, check your model for errors, or draft slides. Rules:

- An AI answer is **not a source**. Every figure must be traceable to a primary source with URL and date. Verify every number an AI tool gives you.
- Be honest: list all tools you used and what you used them for (README sheet and last slide).
- You are responsible for the content. Be ready to explain every choice in your model.
- As in the syllabus, you are graded on the quality, innovativeness and variety of your sources.

11 How the midterm is assessed

The midterm is graded as a group and counts 30 % of the course grade. Indicative weighting of the criteria: [to be confirmed].

Criterion	What we look for	Weight
Fit to the case	Common criteria applied unchanged; the view from Vienna; the hard question is addressed	15 %
Data quality and documentation	Named sources, years and units; missing data handled openly; everything traceable	15 %
Method	Data collected and documented correctly; normalisation, weights and results explained; rubric scores justified	20 %
Robustness	All four alternative weight sets run correctly; honest reading of what they show	15 %
Insight and recommendation	Clear recommendation for your country; says what not to do; states uncertainty; Part B adds real industry insight	20 %
Presentation and Excel	Structure, timing, visuals, answers to questions; clear workbook	15 %

12 Timeline and coaching

When	What
Before session 3	PESTEL indicator sheet completed (proposed criteria with sources) by [date]; data plan for your country
Session 3 (Mon 19 Oct)	Online Zoom coaching (20 minutes per group): criteria, data status, open questions
After session 3	Instructor merges the proposals, selects the final criteria and publishes the shared Country scoring model [date]
Before session 4	Your country's data entered in the shared file; then normalisation, weights, first scores
Session 4 (Mon 9 Nov)	Online Zoom coaching (20 minutes per group): results and first robustness checks
Between sessions 4 and 5 (9 to 16 Nov)	Finish robustness and your recommendation; Part B; rehearse; submit the files on Canvas by Monday 16 November 2026, 08:00
Session 5 (Mon 16 Nov, 08:00)	Midterm presentation

13 Common pitfalls

- **Changing the common criteria.** Other groups depend on your data. Keep definitions, units and years as agreed.
- **Double counting.** GDP, population and imports are strongly correlated.
- **Min-max with six countries.** It stretches tiny differences. Compare it with the T-scores.
- **Treating the fixed weights as the truth.** They are a baseline; report what the other weight sets show.
- **Treating the ranking as the truth.** Report rank ranges and say what would change the order.
- **Ignoring Julius Meinl's model.** A big market without hotels, premium buyers or a feasible partner may not fit.
- **No "what not to do".** A recommendation includes the countries you would not enter now.